

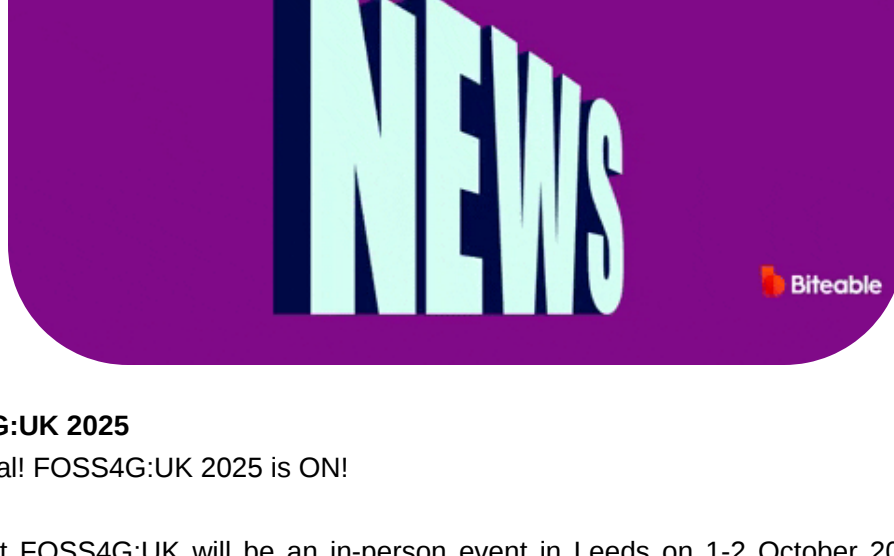


## Welcome to the OSGeo:UK Newsletter

Hello and welcome to the OSGeo:UK newsletter in which we share updates and information every couple of months about the OSGeo:UK local chapter along with general FOSS for geospatial goodness. Please share the newsletter widely. Interested folks can [sign up](#) too. For now, please enjoy this edition.

## News from OSGeo:UK

Find out more about OSGeo:UK and how you can be part of our community on our [website](#).



### FOSS4G:UK 2025

It's official! FOSS4G:UK 2025 is ON!

Our next FOSS4G:UK will be an in-person event in Leeds on 1-2 October 2025. More details and a website will be shared soon so you need to make sure you are following us on social media or on the email list. Alternatively, all of the pertinent information will be in this newsletter and on the OSGeo:UK website.

The main thing that you need to do at the moment is start thinking about your submission for the Call for Talks! We want to hear what you have been up to with Free & Open Source geospatial data and software!

### Communication

As mentioned in the December 2024 newsletter, OSGeo:UK are aware that we have many contact points. As stated, the key ones are the [website](#) (key announcements to the UK community will be posted there), the email mailing list and this newsletter (although this only provides updates every two months).

Alongside the [Mastodon](#) and [BlueSky](#) accounts, we are putting renewed focus on our new page on [LinkedIn](#) which will take over from the longstanding but relatively unused LinkedIn group that exists. If you are on LinkedIn we encourage you to follow the new OSGeo:UK page. See you on the socials!

Finally, we now have the opportunity for readers to [submit news stories](#) that you want highlighted in this newsletter - just fill out the form with suitable details and we will add them to a future newsletter issue.



## OSGeo-related Projects

### GoFundGeo

Following up with some of the projects that were funded through the GoFundGeo scheme, Terra Draw continues to go from strength to strength. James Milner was recently in Brussels promoting the project and explaining its aims at FOSDEM. [FOSDEM](#) is a two-day event organised by volunteers to promote the widespread use of free and open source software, usually taking place in Brussels (Belgium). It is a free and non-commercial event organised by the community for the community with the goal to provide free and open source software developers and communities a place to meet and learn about the latest developments in the free and open source world. If you want to know what James spoke about, check out the [video of his talk here](#). This was part of a dedicated geospatial track, which included other speakers talking about topics such as the Copernicus Data Space Ecosystem and OpenLayers. To find links to videos of the session search for 'geospatial' at this link: <https://fosdem.org/2025/schedule/events/>

A lot has been happening in the Geoserver project, specifically around the crowdfunding that GoFundGeo has helped with and also in terms of updates to the software. By mid-January, 80% of the crowdfunding ask had been reached: the full details are [here](#). It is excellent to see the broad range of supporting organisations, and to see that it isn't the usual large tech companies that are funding it. There is still a need to gather funding for the project, so if your organisation is a Geoserver user please consider asking them to contribute. The project has also recently released the [latest stable version](#), 2.26.2, so it's time to look at updating if you need to.

Additionally, [qgis2web 3.25.0](#) has been released in the last couple of weeks. There's a great wiki [here](#) for the project. The pgRouting repositories have also been busy and all the latest updates for that project can be found [here](#). QGIS has recently announced ([here](#)) a new resource hub which is designed to share things such as styles, models and project details. You can investigate it here: <https://hub.qgis.org>

Remember, everyone on the committee encourages you to submit bids later in the year for a project or projects that you would like to see funded by us.

And finally in this section, we have just passed the [19th birthday of OSGeo!](#) Congratulations everyone - and this means that next year will be a big one!



## Wider software and event news

You'll need to do your travel planning if you are going to attend the [global FOSS4G](#) event in 2025 as it rolls on to Auckland, New Zealand. And closer to home, [FOSS4G Europe 2025](#) will be held in Mostar, Bosnia-Herzegovina in July - which could mean some very exciting trans-European rail journeys if you go for the green travel option.

Whilst we are talking about FOSS4G, the [2026 event will be held in Hiroshima](#) and will celebrate both the 20th anniversary of the OSGeo Foundation and the OSGeo-organised FOSS4G conference.

Which raises the question.... do we want to see FOSS4G back in the UK? If you have a view on that then let us know via our [LinkedIn page](#) or the [mailing list](#) (especially if you want to volunteer!).

### Other events

The AGI (Association for Geographic Information) and OSGeo:UK have been in contact recently given that the two organisations operate in similar worlds. As such we are aiming to support each other's events and promote these as applicable. [GeoCom hosted by AGI Scotland 2025](#) is scheduled for the 27 Feb 2025 and a [full list of the membership events](#) can be found online.

Finally, the [2025 QGIS User Conference](#) is happening in Norrköping, Sweden on the 2-3 June. Ticket sales opened earlier this month and the schedule is due to be updated soon. Keep your eye on their website for details.

### In wider geospatial FOSS news...

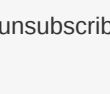
If you are an R user you may have already heard of the [fasterRaster](#) package. It enhances the processing of large raster and vector spatial data by using GRASS GIS functionality, which makes it significantly faster than the traditional R packages such as *terra* or *sf*. It abstracts the complexity of GRASS (which is nice!), allowing efficient workflows.

Key features include a syntax familiar to users of the *terra* and *sf* packages and improved performance for disk-based operations. It needs GRASS 8.3+ to be installed on the system, and for the package to be installed via CRAN or GitHub. The website suggests that the package is particularly useful for spatial data scientists and GIS professionals working with large-scale geospatial datasets in R.

As we are discussing R packages, a new version of *tmap* (v4) has been released and is now available. This is an R package for drawing thematic maps and uses a syntax not dissimilar to that for the popular *ggplot2*, (an R-library for drawing charts). Quite a lot has changed under the hood, creating new flexibility and many more options when using this package. [Check out the website](#) for more details on tmap. Nick Bearman has also [written a blog post detailing the changes](#) between the last and current version, so check that out.

And talking of raster processing, another raster processing package is [Rasteret](#), an open-source Python library designed to enhance the efficiency and cost-effectiveness of accessing open satellite data, particularly Cloud-optimised GeoTIFFs (COGs). By caching only the headers of COG files, Rasteret minimises the need for repeated metadata retrievals, which are common in traditional tools. This approach significantly reduces the number of HTTP requests required, leading to faster data access and lower operational costs. The library builds upon the STAC-GeoParquet framework, extending it with additional columns for per-band metadata which allows the package to efficiently manage and query large collections of imagery. If you are processing large amounts of data that is stored and served over the web then you could do worse than checking out this tool.

We hope that you found this edition of the newsletter interesting and informative. If you have any feedback or comments then let us know!



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